

*Haligric Research Integration Series*

# **Anglicanism and the Episcopal Tradition**

## **A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE**

*The Via Media — Scripture, Tradition, Reason, and the Book of Common Prayer*

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*Thomas Cranmer produced a single compact volume in the language of the people so that "now from henceforth all the Realm shall have but one use." He was burned at the stake by Mary Tudor in 1556. His book survived.*

*The Book of Common Prayer has been described as "the Bible re-arranged for public worship." Its cadences shaped the English language as surely as Shakespeare. John Wesley said there was "no liturgy in the world which breathes more of a solid, scriptural, rational piety."*

*Anglicanism is not a via media between Catholicism and Protestantism. It is a tradition that is fully Protestant in doctrine and fully Catholic in form — and lives in the creative tension between those two inheritances.*

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## Introduction — What Is Anglicanism?

Anglicanism is the branch of Christianity that emerged from the English Reformation of the 16th century — a tradition that is simultaneously Protestant in its theology (salvation by grace through faith, Scripture as the primary authority, rejection of the Pope's jurisdiction) and Catholic in its form (episcopal church government with bishops in apostolic succession, sacramental worship, liturgical practice, and continuity with the ancient Church). This combination — Protestant doctrine in Catholic structures, Reformed theology in ancient forms — is what gives Anglicanism its distinctive character and its characteristic theological tensions.

The worldwide Anglican Communion comprises approximately 85 million members organized in 44 member churches spread across 165 countries, making it the third largest Christian communion after Roman Catholicism and Eastern Orthodoxy. In the United States, the tradition is represented primarily by the Episcopal Church (formally: The Protestant Episcopal Church in the United States of America), which takes its name from the episcopal (bishop-led) form of its governance. In England, it is the Church of England — the established national church with the British monarch as its Supreme Governor.

Anglicanism has never defined itself through a single founding theologian (as Lutheranism is associated with Luther and Calvinism with Calvin), through a comprehensive confessional standard (like the Westminster Confession for Presbyterians), or through a governing doctrinal body with authority to define binding doctrine. Instead, Anglicanism has defined itself primarily through shared worship — the Book of Common Prayer — and through four broad sources of authority that the tradition has come to identify as the Anglican method: Scripture, Tradition, Reason, and Experience. This methodological breadth is simultaneously Anglicanism's greatest strength (its capacity for theological hospitality) and its greatest challenge (the tendency toward doctrinal incoherence when the center does not hold).

This document covers: the historical origins in Henry VIII's break with Rome and Cranmer's shaping of distinctively Anglican worship; the Elizabethan Settlement and the Thirty-Nine Articles; the Chicago-Lambeth Quadrilateral; Richard Hooker's theological method; the three streams of Anglican life (Evangelical, Anglo-Catholic, Broad Church); the Oxford Movement; Anglican theology of Scripture, tradition, and reason; the sacraments; Morning Prayer, Evensong, and the Holy Eucharist in complete sequential form; episcopal governance; apostolic succession; the global Anglican Communion; the current crisis and GAFCON realignment; and Anglican spiritual practice.

## Origins — Henry VIII and the Break with Rome

The origins of Anglicanism are inseparable from the very unspiritual personal ambitions of King Henry VIII (1491-1547) — a fact that Anglicans have always had to acknowledge with some theological awkwardness. Henry was a loyal Catholic who had earned the title "Defender of the Faith" from Pope Leo X in 1521 for his treatise against Luther. The break with Rome had nothing to do with Luther's theology of grace and Scripture; it had to do with Henry's desire to annul his marriage to Catherine of Aragon (who had not produced a male heir) and marry Anne Boleyn.

When Pope Clement VII — politically constrained by Catherine's nephew, Holy Roman Emperor Charles V — refused to grant the annulment, Henry turned to Parliament. The Act of Supremacy (1534) declared the King of England "the only Supreme Head on Earth of the Church of England" — a claim that effectively transferred ecclesiastical jurisdiction from Rome to the English Crown without changing anything in Catholic doctrine or practice. Henry remained theologically conservative; his Six Articles of 1539 reaffirmed transubstantiation, celibacy for priests, and other Catholic doctrines. What had changed was not the theology of the Church of England but its institutional loyalty.

The genuine theological Reformation of the English Church began under Henry's son Edward VI (1547-1553) and was guided primarily by Thomas Cranmer, Archbishop of Canterbury. Cranmer had been influenced by Lutheran and then Reformed theology and used his position to introduce Protestant doctrine into the Church of England with increasing boldness. Under Edward, the Mass was abolished, priests were permitted to marry, images were removed from churches, and — most significantly — the Book of Common Prayer was introduced in 1549 (with a more thoroughly Protestant revision in 1552).

The Reformation was briefly and violently reversed under Mary I (1553-1558), Henry's Catholic daughter by Catherine of Aragon. Mary restored papal obedience and burned approximately 300 Protestants as heretics — including Cranmer himself, who recanted under pressure and then, at the moment of his execution, thrust his right hand (with which he had signed the recantation) first into the fire, saying he would not allow that hand to escape punishment for its betrayal. The Marian persecution created the English Protestant martyrology and produced a deep and lasting popular identification of English national identity with Protestantism.

Elizabeth I (1558-1603), Henry's Protestant daughter by Anne Boleyn, succeeded Mary and established the religious settlement that defines Anglicanism to this day. Aware that her country had been torn by religious conflict and that she governed a people with genuinely diverse religious loyalties, Elizabeth's settlement (formalized in the Acts of Supremacy and Uniformity of 1559 and the Thirty-Nine Articles of 1563) was deliberately constructed to be as inclusive as possible — to define the minimum necessary doctrinal commitments while leaving sufficient room for theological diversity within a common liturgy.

## Thomas Cranmer — The Architect of Anglican Worship

Thomas Cranmer (1489-1556) is the most important figure in Anglican history — more important than Henry VIII, who merely created the political conditions for the Reformation, and more important than the subsequent reformers who developed Anglican theology. Cranmer gave Anglicanism its distinctive voice, its liturgical character, and the text that would shape English-speaking Christianity for five centuries: the Book of Common Prayer.

Cranmer was a scholar and a reformer — cautious in temperament, meticulous in his theological development, moving gradually but inexorably from a conservative humanist Catholicism through Lutheran influence to an engagement with the Reformed tradition of Bucer and Calvin. As Archbishop of Canterbury under Henry VIII and then Edward VI, he was the primary instrument through which Protestant doctrine was introduced into the English church — not through controversial pamphlets (as Luther) but through liturgy. By changing the prayers the English people said in church, Cranmer changed what the English people believed.

The Book of Common Prayer of 1549 was deliberately moderate — designed to be acceptable to those with conservative Catholic sensibilities while embedding the theology of justification by faith and rejection of transubstantiation in its language. The 1552 revision was more overtly Protestant, removing the remaining ambiguities about eucharistic presence and moving decisively in a Reformed direction. Together, these two prayer books established the liturgical tradition that would define Anglican worship — in English, accessible to laypeople, organized around the rhythm of daily Morning and Evening Prayer and the weekly Eucharist, saturated with Scripture.

Cranmer's literary achievement is immense: the cadences of the Book of Common Prayer shaped the English language alongside the King James Bible. The sonorous prose of the collects (brief prayers for specific occasions), the measured rhythm of the confessions and absolutions, the majestic language of the eucharistic prayers — these texts entered the bloodstream of English literature and English spiritual sensibility. John Wesley, writing nearly two centuries later, praised the Book of Common Prayer as breathing "more of a solid, scriptural, rational piety" than any other liturgy in the world.

## The Book of Common Prayer

The Book of Common Prayer (BCP) is the defining text of Anglicanism — not a theological treatise but a liturgy, not a confession of faith but a book of worship that embeds its theology in the prayers the community prays together. The principle "lex orandi, lex credendi" (the law of praying is the law of believing) is central to Anglican identity: Anglicans know what they believe by attending to what they pray.

The 1662 Book of Common Prayer — produced after the Restoration of Charles II, following the Puritan interregnum — became the standard that all subsequent Anglican prayer books around the world took as their starting point. It contains: the orders for Morning Prayer and Evening Prayer (the Daily Office); the Litany; the Collects, Epistles, and Gospels for every Sunday and feast day; the Order for Holy Communion (the Eucharist); the Offices of Baptism, Confirmation, Marriage, Visitation of the Sick, Burial; the Psalter (all 150 psalms arranged for monthly reading); the Ordinal (the form for ordaining deacons, priests, and bishops); and the Thirty-Nine Articles.

The prayer book described as "the Bible re-arranged for public worship": its genius was the way it organized systematic biblical reading — the entire New Testament read through multiple times per year, the Old Testament once per year, the entire Psalter read once per month — into a framework of daily prayer that connected the English people to Scripture in a way the pre-Reformation Latin liturgy had not.

Each national church in the Anglican Communion has developed its own prayer book adapted to local language and culture. The American Episcopal Church's 1979 Book of Common Prayer is perhaps the most significant revision, shifting the primary Sunday service from Morning Prayer to the Holy Eucharist, introducing more contemporary English, and emphasizing baptismal theology. The Church of England's Common Worship (2000) and various other provincial books represent the ongoing liturgical development of the tradition. Despite these variations, the family resemblance is unmistakable: the Anglican liturgical tradition is recognizable across cultures by its shape, its cadence, and its saturation with Scripture.

## The Elizabethan Settlement — The Via Media Takes Shape

The Elizabethan Settlement of 1559-1563 established the doctrinal and liturgical framework of Anglicanism as a distinct tradition — a church that was Protestant in its rejection of Rome and Catholic in its retention of episcopal structure, liturgical worship, and continuity with the pre-Reformation Church. Elizabeth I was a politician as much as a theologian (possibly more), and the genius of her settlement lay in its strategic ambiguity: it defined what was required for conformity while leaving open many contested theological questions on which English Christians genuinely disagreed.

The Act of Supremacy (1559) made Elizabeth "Supreme Governor" of the Church of England — the modest title than "Supreme Head" that Henry had claimed, acknowledging that Christ alone is head of the Church. The Act of Uniformity required all churches to use the revised Book of Common Prayer (a moderate revision of the 1552 book) and imposed penalties for absence from church services. The Thirty-Nine Articles (1563) provided a doctrinal statement that was Reformed in its soteriology (salvation by grace through faith, predestination, rejection of transubstantiation) while being deliberately brief and avoiding the most controversial specificities of Calvinist predestination.

The via media — the middle way — that resulted was not the theological equivalent of a compromise between two positions. Elizabeth's settlement was not "half Catholic and half Protestant." It was a Protestant settlement in its theology and an episcopally organized, liturgically conservative settlement in its institutional form. The ambiguity was strategic: by not requiring subscription to a fully elaborated Calvinist soteriology, Elizabeth could keep a much broader spectrum of English Christians within the established church than a more rigorous doctrinal settlement would have permitted.

The chief theological challenge of the Elizabethan Settlement was its opponents on both sides. The Puritans (broadly speaking, those influenced by Continental Reformed theology) wanted a more thorough reform — the removal of remaining Catholic ceremonial elements, the replacement of episcopal government with Presbyterian government, and a more thoroughly Calvinist doctrinal standard. The recusants (English Catholics who refused to conform to the Elizabethan Settlement) maintained their loyalty to Rome. Both groups were eventually suppressed; the Puritan movement ultimately produced the English Civil War and the brief triumph of Calvinist Presbyterianism under Cromwell, before the Restoration of 1660 restored the episcopal settlement.

## The Thirty-Nine Articles

The Thirty-Nine Articles of Religion (1563, revised 1571) are the historic doctrinal statement of the Church of England — a brief (by 16th-century confessional standards) set of doctrinal affirmations and rejections designed to define Anglican doctrine in relation to both Roman Catholicism and the Continental Reformation. They are Reformed in their basic soteriology, anti-Catholic in their specific rejections, and deliberately ambiguous on some of the most contested theological questions.

The Articles affirm: the authority of Scripture as the sufficient rule of faith (Articles 6-8); salvation by grace through faith (Article 11); the two sacraments of Baptism and Holy Communion as dominical sacraments (Article 25); rejection of transubstantiation (Article 28); rejection of the sacrifice of the Mass (Article 31); and the authority of the historic episcopate. They reject: Roman Catholic claims about purgatory, indulgences, the invocation of saints, and the Mass as a propitiatory sacrifice.

The Articles' treatment of predestination (Article 17) is notably brief and careful: it affirms that God predestines those whom he has chosen to salvation, and that for the elect the doctrine is "full of sweet, pleasant, and unspeakable comfort." But it says nothing about reprobation (the predestination of the non-elect to damnation), and it explicitly warns against those who "curl themselves up in the purposes of God" by speculating beyond what Scripture clearly reveals. This strategic restraint distinguishes the Anglican approach from the more explicit double predestination of the Westminster Standards.

The status of the Thirty-Nine Articles within contemporary Anglicanism is contested. In the Church of England, clergy are required to acknowledge them as "agreeable to the Word of God" — a weaker subscription than requiring belief in their specific content. The American Episcopal Church has never required subscription to the Articles, though they remain in the back of the prayer book as a historical document. Conservative Anglican bodies typically treat the Articles as normative; liberal Anglican bodies often ignore them as relics of a more controversial era.



## The Chicago-Lambeth Quadrilateral

The Chicago-Lambeth Quadrilateral (1888) is the concise summary of Anglican identity that has served as the basis for Anglican ecumenical dialogue — a statement of four essentials that define what Anglican churches consider necessary for the visible unity of the Church:

1. THE HOLY SCRIPTURES of the Old and New Testaments as "containing all things necessary to salvation," and as being the rule and ultimate standard of faith.

2. THE APOSTLES' CREED as the Baptismal Symbol, and the NICENE CREED as the sufficient statement of the Christian faith.

3. THE TWO SACRAMENTS ordained by Christ Himself — Baptism and the Supper of the Lord — ministered with unfailing use of Christ's Words of Institution, and of the elements ordained by Him.

4. THE HISTORIC EPISCOPATE, locally adapted in the methods of its administration to the varying needs of the nations and peoples called of God into the Unity of His Church.

The Quadrilateral has served as the starting point for Anglican ecumenical conversations with Roman Catholics (the Anglican-Roman Catholic International Commission, ARCIC), Eastern Orthodox churches, Lutheran churches (full communion has been achieved with the Evangelical Lutheran Church in America through the Called to Common Mission agreement of 2001), and Reformed churches. Its fourth point — the historic episcopate — has been the primary sticking point in ecumenical dialogue, particularly with Protestant bodies that do not maintain the episcopal succession.

The Quadrilateral also functions as an internal Anglican self-description: what makes a church Anglican is not subscription to a specific confession but participation in these four marks. This is why the Anglican Communion can include churches as theologically diverse as the conservative Global Anglican Future Conference (GAFCON) churches of Africa and the progressive Episcopal Church in the United States — both are episcopally ordered, use a prayer book, affirm the creeds and the dominical sacraments, and appeal to Scripture. Their disagreements are profound; but they share the four marks.

## Richard Hooker and the Three-Legged Stool

Richard Hooker (1554-1600) is the greatest theologian the Anglican tradition has produced — the figure who gave the via media its intellectual foundation in his massive work *Of the Laws of Ecclesiastical Polity* (1594-1597). Writing against the Puritan critics who demanded a more thoroughly Reformed church, Hooker articulated the distinctively Anglican approach to religious authority: Scripture is the primary source, but it is interpreted in light of the Church's tradition and through the exercise of reason.

The metaphor of the "three-legged stool" — Scripture, Tradition, and Reason as the three legs of Anglican authority — is associated with Hooker, though he did not use the specific image. His actual argument was more nuanced: Scripture is the supreme authority on matters necessary to salvation, but not all matters of church life are specified in Scripture. For questions on which Scripture does not speak directly, the Church is guided by tradition (the accumulated wisdom of the Church's history) and by reason (the God-given human capacity for rational judgment about what is fitting and expedient). To those who said that what Scripture does not command is forbidden, Hooker responded that what Scripture does not forbid is permitted — a direct engagement with the Puritan regulative principle.

Hooker's approach gave Anglicanism a theological method rather than a theological system. Where Lutheranism has the Five Solas and the Lutheran Confessions, and Calvinism has TULIP and the Westminster Standards, Anglicanism has a method — a way of doing theology that is simultaneously rooted in Scripture, informed by tradition, and open to rational inquiry. This methodological openness is what makes Anglicanism simultaneously its most distinctive gift (its capacity for theological hospitality and intellectual engagement) and its most persistent vulnerability (the tendency, absent a firm doctrinal center, toward theological drift).

Some Anglican theologians add a fourth source — Experience — to Scripture, Tradition, and Reason, creating the "Anglican Quadrilateral" of theological method (not to be confused with the Chicago-Lambeth Quadrilateral of ecclesiastical essentials). The experiential dimension acknowledges the role of lived Christian experience, including spiritual experience, in theological reflection. This fourfold method — Scripture, Tradition, Reason, Experience — is sometimes criticized as reducing theology to subjective preference; its defenders argue that it is the most honest available account of how theological knowledge is actually developed.

# **The Three Streams — Evangelical, Anglo-Catholic, Broad Church**

Anglicanism has never been a theologically homogeneous tradition. The Elizabethan Settlement's strategic ambiguity created space for multiple theological tendencies within a single institutional church, and over centuries these tendencies have crystallized into distinct streams or parties — sometimes called "churchmanship traditions" — that represent genuinely different theological emphases, liturgical styles, and spiritual sensibilities within the Anglican family.

## **Evangelical Anglicanism**

Evangelical Anglicanism emphasizes the Protestant heritage of the Elizabethan Reformation — the authority of Scripture, justification by grace through faith, the centrality of preaching, and a relatively simple, Scripture-focused liturgical style. The evangelical stream draws on the 18th-century evangelical revival associated with the Clapham Sect (who led the campaign to abolish the slave trade), William Wilberforce, and the renewal movements within the Church of England that preceded and accompanied John Wesley's Methodist movement. Contemporary evangelical Anglicanism includes both traditional Prayer Book evangelicals (who combine Reformed theology with liturgical worship) and charismatic evangelicals (who have incorporated elements of the charismatic renewal movement). The evangelical stream has been the primary driver of Anglican missionary expansion globally and is the dominant theological tendency in the Global South Anglican churches.

## **Anglo-Catholic Anglicanism**

Anglo-Catholic Anglicanism emphasizes the Catholic heritage of the English Church — its continuity with the pre-Reformation Western Catholic tradition, its sacramental theology, its liturgical richness (vestments, incense, candles, frequent celebration of the Eucharist), and its apostolic succession as the guarantee of valid sacraments. Anglo-Catholicism emerged primarily from the Oxford Movement of the 19th century (covered in the next section) and represents an understanding of Anglicanism as genuinely Catholic — not a Protestant denomination that has retained some Catholic forms, but a Catholic church that has been reformed in its doctrine. The most extreme expression is the Anglo-papalist tendency, which seeks full reunion with Rome. More mainstream Anglo-Catholicism maintains a "branch theory" of the Church, in which the Anglican, Roman Catholic, and Eastern Orthodox traditions are understood as three branches of the one holy catholic and apostolic church.

## **Broad Church / Liberal Anglicanism**

Broad Church Anglicanism (also called liberal or progressive Anglicanism) emphasizes the rational, intellectual, and inclusive dimensions of the tradition — the commitment to honest theological inquiry, the engagement with contemporary scholarship, and the pastoral priority of welcoming the maximum possible range of people within the church's life. The broad church tradition has its roots in the 19th-century liberal theology associated with the Essays and Reviews controversy (1860) and the Lux Mundi movement, and in the 20th century it produced the "death of God" theology associated with Bishop John A. T. Robinson's *Honest to God* (1963). Contemporary progressive Anglicanism has been the leading edge of the ordination of women (the Church of England began ordaining women priests in 1994 and women bishops in 2014; the Episcopal Church ordained the first female bishop in 1989), the inclusion of LGBTQ+ clergy and couples, and the blessing of same-sex marriages.

## The Oxford Movement and Anglo-Catholicism

The Oxford Movement (1833-1845) was the most significant theological development in Anglican history since the Elizabethan Settlement — a movement centered at the University of Oxford that sought to recover what its leaders believed was Anglicanism's authentic Catholic heritage, against what they saw as the dangerous encroachment of liberal rationalism and state interference in the Church.

The movement began on July 14, 1833, when John Keble preached a sermon before the University of Oxford titled "National Apostasy" — a protest against the government's proposal to suppress several Irish Anglican bishoprics. Newman dated the Oxford Movement from this sermon. The Tractarians (Keble, Newman, Edward Pusey, Richard Hurrell Froude) began publishing the Tracts for the Times — 90 pamphlets arguing for the Catholic identity of the Church of England, the importance of apostolic succession, the sacramental character of baptism and the Eucharist, and the devotional and liturgical practices of the patristic and medieval Church.

The crisis of the movement came with Newman's final tract, Tract 90 (1841), in which he argued that the Thirty-Nine Articles could be interpreted in a Catholic sense — that their rejections of specifically Roman Catholic doctrines did not necessarily conflict with Catholic doctrine more broadly understood. The reaction was fierce; many saw Tract 90 as the thin end of a wedge toward Rome. Newman's doubts about the Anglican Church's Catholic identity deepened; in 1845 he was received into the Roman Catholic Church, eventually becoming a cardinal. Newman's conversion was the movement's most dramatic moment and its most significant crisis — demonstrating that the Catholic identity of Anglicanism could lead, in certain configurations, to Roman Catholicism.

Despite Newman's conversion, the Oxford Movement profoundly and permanently shaped Anglicanism. The Anglo-Catholic stream it generated revived: the use of vestments and ceremonial in worship, the frequent celebration of the Eucharist (which had often been celebrated monthly or less frequently before the movement), the practice of confession and spiritual direction, the religious life for men and women in orders (Anglican monasteries and convents were founded in the 19th century for the first time since the Reformation), the recovery of the patristic inheritance, and a renewed emphasis on the Church's Catholic identity as a community of Word and Sacrament rather than merely a preaching station.

## Anglican Theology — Scripture, Tradition, and Reason

Anglican theology resists systematic definition more than any other major Protestant tradition, because Anglicanism has self-consciously chosen a method (Scripture, Tradition, Reason) over a system. This means that within the Anglican Communion, one finds theologians holding positions that in other traditions would be clearly incompatible: on the one hand, evangelical Anglicans who affirm biblical inerrancy and substitutionary atonement; on the other, liberal Anglicans who understand Scripture as a human document requiring critical scholarship and who interpret the atonement in non-penal terms. Both claim to be Anglican; both can point to Anglican theological sources.

The core theological commitments that virtually all Anglicans share — the Chicago-Lambeth Quadrilateral plus the doctrinal content of the Thirty-Nine Articles — are actually substantial. Anglicanism affirms the doctrine of the Trinity as expressed in the Nicene Creed, the two natures of Christ as defined at Chalcedon, salvation by grace through faith, the authority of Scripture as the primary rule of faith, the two dominical sacraments, and the historic episcopate. These are not nothing; they represent the full inheritance of the ecumenical creeds and the Reformation's recovery of evangelical soteriology.

What Anglicanism does not have — and what its critics most frequently note — is a mechanism for enforcing doctrinal boundaries. The Anglican Communion has no magisterium, no authoritative teaching office with jurisdiction over member churches. The Lambeth Conference (the gathering of all Anglican bishops every ten years) passes resolutions, but they are not binding. The Archbishop of Canterbury has moral authority but no jurisdictional authority outside the Church of England. This means that theological drift, once it begins in one part of the Communion, cannot easily be stopped by the rest.

## The Sacraments in Anglican Theology

Anglicanism formally recognizes two dominical sacraments — Baptism and Holy Communion — as sacraments "ordained by Christ himself" in the sense intended by the Thirty-Nine Articles and the Chicago-Lambeth Quadrilateral. The other five rites recognized by the Catholic tradition (Confirmation, Marriage, Ordination, Penance, and Unction) are affirmed as meaningful and important but are described in Article 25 as "commonly called sacraments" that "have not the like nature of Sacraments with Baptism, and the Lord's Supper, for that they have not any visible sign or ceremony ordained of God."

**BAPTISM:** Anglican baptismal theology is generous — most provinces practice infant baptism, understanding it as a rite of initiation into the covenant community that conveys grace and incorporates the person into the Body of Christ. The 1979 American prayer book particularly emphasizes baptism as "full initiation into Christ's Body, the Church" — a shift that has generated the "baptismal covenant" as a central theological concept in progressive American Anglicanism. The baptismal covenant (renouncing evil, believing in the Triune God, continuing in the apostles' teaching, seeking and serving Christ in all persons, striving for justice and peace) has become a touchstone for social justice theology in the Episcopal Church.

**THE EUCHARIST:** Anglican eucharistic theology is deliberately ambiguous — another consequence of the Elizabethan settlement's strategic openness. The Thirty-Nine Articles (Article 28) reject transubstantiation ("the change of the substance of Bread and Wine in the Supper of the Lord cannot be proved by Holy Writ, but is repugnant to the plain words of Scripture, overthroweth the nature of a Sacrament") while affirming that "the Body of Christ is given, taken, and eaten in the Supper, only after an heavenly and spiritual manner." This formulation is deliberately imprecise about the mechanism of Christ's presence, excluding the Catholic doctrine while not specifying a Reformed symbolic interpretation. Anglo-Catholics within the communion have interpreted it in terms close to Catholic sacramental realism; evangelicals have interpreted it in a more spiritual or receptionist direction.

## Anglican Worship — Morning Prayer and Evensong

The Anglican worship tradition is built on a rhythm of daily prayer and weekly (or more frequent) Eucharist. The daily prayer tradition — Morning Prayer and Evening Prayer (Evensong) — is the backbone of Anglican spirituality and the most directly Cranmerian inheritance. Before the Anglo-Catholic revival of the 19th century, Morning Prayer was typically the primary Sunday service in most parishes; the Eucharist was celebrated monthly or quarterly. Since the liturgical movement of the 20th century, the Eucharist has been restored as the primary act of Sunday worship in most Anglican provinces, with the Daily Office (Morning and Evening Prayer) continuing as the framework for daily prayer.

The genius of the Anglican Daily Office is its simplicity and its saturation with Scripture. Morning Prayer consists essentially of a brief introduction (opening versicles and responses), the recitation of psalms, the reading of Scripture (an Old Testament and a New Testament reading), the singing of canticles (biblical songs — the Venite from Psalm 95, the Te Deum, the Benedictus from Luke 1), the Apostles' Creed, the Lord's Prayer, a set of fixed collects, and a concluding prayer. Evening Prayer (Evensong) follows the same pattern with different canticles (the Magnificat from Luke 1, the Nunc Dimittis from Luke 2). The entire psalter is read through over a month (in the traditional BCP) or other cycles; the Old and New Testaments are read through systematically over the course of each year.

## Morning Prayer — The Complete Order

The following is the traditional order of Morning Prayer from the 1662 Book of Common Prayer, which remains the standard for the worldwide Anglican Communion:

**OPENING SENTENCE:** A verse of Scripture appropriate to the season, read by the officiant.

**EXHORTATION:** The officiant invites the congregation to acknowledge their sins to God: "Dearly beloved brethren, the Scripture moveth us in sundry places to acknowledge and confess our manifold sins and wickedness..."

**GENERAL CONFESSION:** The entire congregation kneels and confesses together: "Almighty and most merciful Father, we have erred and strayed from Thy ways like lost sheep. We have followed too much the devices and desires of our own hearts. We have offended against Thy holy laws. We have left undone those things which we ought to have done, and we have done those things which we ought not to have done, and there is no health in us. But Thou, O Lord, have mercy upon us miserable offenders..."

**ABSOLUTION:** The priest (not the layperson officiating if there is no priest present) pronounces the absolution: "Almighty God, the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who desireth not the death of a sinner, but rather that he may turn from his wickedness and live, hath given power and commandment to his Ministers to declare and pronounce to his people, being penitent, the Absolution and Remission of their sins..."

**THE LORD'S PRAYER:** Said by all together.

**VERSICLES AND RESPONSES:** A brief antiphonal exchange between officiant and people, including "O Lord, open thou our lips / And our mouth shall show forth thy praise."

**THE VENITE:** Psalm 95 sung or said — "O come, let us sing unto the Lord; let us heartily rejoice in the strength of our salvation. Let us come before his presence with thanksgiving; and show ourselves glad in him with psalms..."

**THE PSALMS:** The appointed psalms for the day, from the monthly cycle. Sung antiphonally between two sides of the choir (or officiant and congregation), or said in unison.

**THE FIRST LESSON:** An Old Testament reading, followed by the Te Deum (on most days) or the Benedicite (on other occasions). The Te Deum is the great ancient hymn of praise: "We praise thee, O God; we acknowledge thee to be the Lord. All the earth doth worship thee, the Father everlasting..."

**THE SECOND LESSON:** A New Testament reading, followed by the Benedictus ("Blessed be the Lord God of Israel, for he hath visited and redeemed his people...") or the Jubilate (Psalm 100: "O be joyful in the Lord, all ye lands...").

**THE APOSTLES' CREED:** Said standing by all.

**THE LORD'S PRAYER:** Said again by all.

**THE LESSER LITANY:** "O Lord, show thy mercy upon us / And grant us thy salvation / O Lord, save the Queen / And mercifully hear us when we call upon thee..."

**THE COLLECTS:** Three fixed collects: the Collect of the Day (which changes each Sunday and feast day), the Collect for Peace ("O God, who art the author of peace and lover of concord..."), and the Collect for Grace ("O Lord, our heavenly Father, Almighty and everlasting God, who hast safely brought us to the beginning of this day...").

**ADDITIONAL PRAYERS:** State prayers, prayers for the clergy and people, and other occasional prayers.



## ANTHEM OR CLOSING HYMN.

GRACE: "The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, and the love of God, and the fellowship of the Holy Ghost, be with us all evermore. Amen."

Evensong follows the same structure with different canticles (Magnificat and Nunc Dimittis instead of Te Deum and Benedictus) and evening-appropriate collects. In cathedral and collegiate settings, Evensong is sung chorally — the canticles set to Anglican chant or to through-composed anthems — in a tradition of choral music that has produced some of the most beautiful sacred music in Western Christianity.

## **The Holy Eucharist — The Central Act of Anglican Worship**

The Holy Eucharist (Holy Communion, the Mass, the Lord's Supper — all names used within Anglican practice depending on the theological tradition of the parish) has become, since the liturgical movement of the 20th century, the primary act of Sunday worship in most Anglican and Episcopal churches. The service in its 1979 American prayer book form (Rite II — contemporary language) is the most widely used Anglican eucharistic liturgy in the world by number of communicants.

Anglican eucharistic theology, as noted above, is deliberately broad — affirming Christ's presence in the Supper while not specifying the mechanism. The prayer books are carefully worded to support both a more Catholic and a more Protestant reading. This breadth means that Anglo-Catholic parishes celebrating the Eucharist with incense, bells, and elaborate vestments and evangelical parishes celebrating with minimal ceremony and contemporary language are recognizably doing the same rite — the same texts, the same structure — while embodying very different understandings of what is happening.

## The Eucharist Step-by-Step

The following order is from the 1979 American Book of Common Prayer, Rite II (Holy Eucharist), which is the standard for the Episcopal Church in the United States:

### The Word of God

OPENING ACCLAMATION: The presider opens: "Blessed be God: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit." People: "And blessed be his kingdom, now and for ever. Amen." (In Easter season: "Alleluia. Christ is risen. / The Lord is risen indeed. Alleluia.")

COLLECT FOR PURITY: An ancient prayer attributed to Cranmer: "Almighty God, to you all hearts are open, all desires known, and from you no secrets are hid: Cleanse the thoughts of our hearts by the inspiration of your Holy Spirit, that we may perfectly love you, and worthily magnify your holy Name; through Christ our Lord."

GLORIA IN EXCELSIS or KYRIE: The Gloria is sung or said on most Sundays and festivals. The Kyrie ("Lord have mercy, Christ have mercy, Lord have mercy") is used in penitential seasons.

THE COLLECT OF THE DAY: A brief prayer gathering the theme of the day.

THE LESSONS: Old Testament reading, psalm (sung responsively or in unison), Epistle reading. Each concludes: "The Word of the Lord / Thanks be to God."

THE GOSPEL: The deacon or priest reads the Gospel, preceded by the Alleluia (or, in Lent, a Tract). The congregation stands. "The Holy Gospel of our Lord Jesus Christ according to N. / Glory to you, Lord Christ." After: "The Gospel of the Lord / Praise to you, Lord Christ."

THE SERMON: The homily, expounding the Scripture readings.

THE NICENE CREED: Confessed together by the assembly, standing.

THE PRAYERS OF THE PEOPLE: Intercessions offered in one of six traditional forms, with the congregation responding after each petition. The prayers cover the Church, the world, the local community, the sick, the dead, and the gathered assembly.

CONFESSION OF SIN: A corporate confession, followed by the priest's absolution.

THE PEACE: The presider says "The peace of the Lord be always with you / And also with you." Members of the congregation greet each other. This is one of the most visible expressions of Anglican hospitality and community — the exchange of the peace marks the transition from the Ministry of the Word to the Ministry of the Table.

### The Holy Table

THE OFFERTORY: The bread and wine are brought to the altar; the financial offerings of the people are received. An offertory sentence from Scripture is read.

THE GREAT THANKSGIVING: The central act of the Eucharist, a prayer of thanksgiving over the bread and wine. It opens with the ancient Sursum Corda:

"The Lord be with you / And also with you / Lift up your hearts / We lift them to the Lord / Let us give thanks to the Lord our God / It is right to give him thanks and praise."

The presider continues with the Preface — a thanksgiving that varies with the season and occasion — leading to the Sanctus: "Holy, holy, holy Lord, God of power and might / Heaven and earth are full of your glory / Hosanna in the highest / Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord / Hosanna in the highest."

The prayer continues with the institution narrative: "On the night he was handed over to suffering and death, our Lord Jesus Christ took bread; and when he had given thanks to you, he broke it, and gave it to his disciples, and said, 'Take, eat: This is my Body, which is given for you. Do this for the remembrance of me.'" Similarly with the cup: "This is my Blood of the new Covenant, which is shed for you and for many for the forgiveness of sins. Whenever you drink it, do this for the remembrance of me."

The Memorial Acclamation follows: "Therefore we proclaim the mystery of faith: Christ has died. Christ is risen. Christ will come again." The prayer continues with the epiclesis (invocation of the Holy Spirit over the gifts), commemorations of the living and dead, and the doxology: "Through Christ, and with Christ, and in Christ, in the unity of the Holy Spirit, to you be honor and glory, now and for ever. AMEN."

THE LORD'S PRAYER: Said or sung by all together.

THE BREAKING OF THE BREAD (FRACTION): The presider breaks the consecrated bread in silence (or with a proper fraction anthem). "Alleluia. Christ our Passover is sacrificed for us / Therefore let us keep the feast. Alleluia."

COMMUNION: The presider and people commune. Ministers and lay eucharistic ministers distribute the bread and the cup. The words of administration: "The Body of Christ, the bread of heaven. / The Blood of Christ, the cup of salvation."

POST-COMMUNION PRAYER: A prayer of thanksgiving after Communion, offered by all together.

BLESSING: The presider blesses the congregation.

DISMISSAL: The deacon or presider dismisses the assembly: "Go in peace to love and serve the Lord / Thanks be to God." Or in Easter season: "Alleluia, alleluia / Thanks be to God. Alleluia, alleluia."

## Episcopal Church Government

Anglicanism is episcopally organized — governed by bishops (Greek: episkopos — overseer) — and this episcopal polity is one of the four marks of Anglican identity in the Chicago-Lambeth Quadrilateral. The threefold order of bishops, priests, and deacons is the Anglican inherited form of Christian ministry, traced to the apostolic Church and maintained through continuous ordination.

**THE BISHOP:** The chief pastor and teacher of a diocese — a geographical region encompassing multiple congregations. The bishop ordains priests and deacons, confirms the baptized, and has primary responsibility for the doctrinal and disciplinary life of the diocese. In the Church of England, some bishops sit in the House of Lords (the Lords Spiritual) — one of the most ancient expressions of the church-state relationship in the Anglican tradition.

**THE PRIEST:** The ordained minister of a parish — responsible for the regular celebration of the Eucharist, the preaching of the Word, the pastoral care of the congregation, and the administration of the sacraments (except ordination). Anglican priests may be married (unlike most Catholic priests in the Western Church); since 1994 in the Church of England and since 1977 in the Episcopal Church, women have been ordained to the priesthood.

**THE DEACON:** A distinct order of ministry, ordained to serve — specifically to the poor, the weak, the sick, and the lonely. The deacon's liturgical role is to read the Gospel, lead the Prayers of the People, and assist at the Eucharist; the deacon's primary vocation is service in the world. The permanent diaconate (deacons who do not proceed to the priesthood) is available to both men and women in most Anglican provinces.

The governance structure of Anglican churches is synodical — legislative bodies (synods) at the parish, diocesan, and national level include representation from all three orders (bishops, clergy, laity). In the Church of England, the General Synod comprises the House of Bishops, the House of Clergy, and the House of Laity; major decisions require approval from all three houses. This "two integrities" or "mixed polity" — episcopal leadership combined with synodical accountability — is another expression of the *via media* between episcopal authority and congregational participation.

## **Apostolic Succession in the Anglican Tradition**

Apostolic succession — the unbroken chain of episcopal ordination from the apostles to the present — is central to Anglican identity, particularly for Anglo-Catholics. The claim is that Anglican bishops stand in a continuous line of consecration from the apostolic Church, transmitted through the medieval Church and maintained through the Reformation.

The validity of Anglican orders has been contested. Pope Leo XIII declared Anglican ordinations "absolutely null and utterly void" in the apostolic letter *Apostolicae Curae* (1896), on the grounds that the Edwardian Ordinal of 1550 (the form used for ordaining Anglican bishops during the Reformation) had defective intention and defective form — it did not specifically mention the order of bishop or priest being conferred. Anglican theologians have responded in the *Saepius Officio* (1897), arguing that the Ordinal was sufficient and that Leo's judgment was mistaken. The question remains officially unresolved between Rome and Canterbury.

The Orthodox churches similarly do not recognize the validity of Anglican orders, primarily because of the theological changes introduced during the Reformation and the question of whether Anglican sacramental theology maintains the necessary understanding of holy orders as a sacrament. ARCIC discussions with Rome and Orthodox-Anglican dialogues have engaged these questions without resolving them.

Within the Anglican Communion itself, the validity of orders is not questioned — all Anglican bishops, priests, and deacons ordained according to Anglican rites are recognized across the Communion. The ecumenical question of orders has been addressed in some cases through joint ordinations: in some Anglican-Lutheran full communion agreements, bishops are ordained with the participation of both Anglican and Lutheran bishops, creating a shared episcopal succession.

## **The Anglican Communion — A Global Family**

The Anglican Communion is the worldwide association of churches that are in communion with the Archbishop of Canterbury and with each other — 44 member churches in 165 countries, with approximately 85 million members. It is organized not as a single international church with a governing hierarchy but as a fellowship of self-governing provincial churches that share a common heritage, expressed through the Book of Common Prayer, the historic episcopate, and the four marks of the Chicago-Lambeth Quadrilateral.

The instruments of Anglican unity — the bodies that hold the Communion together — are: the Archbishop of Canterbury (the symbolic head of the Communion, with moral rather than jurisdictional authority outside England); the Lambeth Conference (the gathering of all Anglican bishops every ten years, whose resolutions are advisory rather than binding); the Anglican Consultative Council (a representative body of bishops, clergy, and laity from member churches); and the Primates' Meeting (the senior bishops of each member church, meeting for prayer and consultation).

The Anglican Communion has been deeply divided in the late 20th and early 21st centuries over issues of human sexuality — specifically the blessing of same-sex unions and the ordination and consecration of LGBTQ+ clergy and bishops. The election and consecration of Gene Robinson as the first openly gay bishop in the Episcopal Church (Diocese of New Hampshire, 2003) triggered a crisis that has not been resolved. Conservative Global South churches (especially in Africa, where Anglican Christianity is growing rapidly) view the Episcopal Church's and Anglican Church of Canada's actions as departures from biblical teaching that put them outside authentic Anglican Christianity.

## **The Episcopal Church in the United States**

The Protestant Episcopal Church in the United States of America (ECUSA, commonly called The Episcopal Church or TEC) is the American province of the Anglican Communion — a church with approximately 1.6 million active members in approximately 6,500 congregations. It is organized into about 100 dioceses across the United States and several other countries (including Taiwan, Honduras, and Micronesia).

The Episcopal Church was formally organized after the American Revolution, when the political break with Britain necessitated a reorganization of the colonial Church of England. At the first General Convention (1789), the American prayer book was authorized and the church's constitution and canons were adopted. Samuel Seabury (1729-1796) became the first American bishop, consecrated in 1784 by Scottish Episcopal bishops after the Church of England declined to consecrate an American bishop (since the traditional oath of loyalty to the Crown would have been inappropriate for a citizen of an independent republic).

The Episcopal Church has been one of the most progressive major Protestant churches in the United States over the past half century. Women were ordained as priests beginning in 1977 (following the controversial irregular ordinations of 1974) and as bishops from 1989. The 2003 consecration of Gene Robinson as the first openly gay bishop, and the subsequent blessing of same-sex unions (2009) and marriage (2015), have placed the Episcopal Church at the progressive end of the global Anglican Communion and have contributed to significant defections to conservative Anglican bodies, including the Anglican Church in North America (ACNA), which was formed in 2009 as a conservative alternative to TEC.



## **The Anglican Crisis — GAFCON and the Realignment**

The Anglican Communion has been in formal or semi-formal schism since approximately 2003, when the Global Anglican Future Conference (GAFCON) — a coalition of conservative Anglican primates primarily from Africa, Asia, and Latin America — began meeting separately from the instruments of Communion and eventually declared themselves the authentic expression of Anglicanism.

The conservative African churches represent the demographic future of Anglicanism: the Anglican Church of Nigeria has approximately 20 million members; the Anglican Church of Uganda has approximately 10 million; the Church of the Province of Kenya has approximately 4 million. These African churches, whose growth has been explosive in the post-colonial era, hold theologically conservative positions on human sexuality rooted in their understanding of biblical authority. They have, with increasing directness, declared that the Episcopal Church and the Anglican Church of Canada have departed from authentic Christian teaching and that the Archbishop of Canterbury's unwillingness to discipline these churches constitutes a failure of the Communion's instruments of unity.

The GAFCON Primates' Council meeting of October 2025 made its most decisive statement yet: declaring GAFCON itself to be the authentic Anglican Communion, and stating that communion with Canterbury had become a disqualifying mark rather than a qualifying mark of Anglican identity for those who wished to be part of genuine Anglicanism. This represents an effective formal schism, though it remains unclear whether Canterbury, the other Communion instruments, or the liberal Anglican churches will acknowledge it as such.

The Anglican realignment reflects a broader fault line in global Christianity: between the declining but theologically progressive churches of the Western world (Episcopal USA, Church of England, Anglican Church of Canada) and the rapidly growing but theologically conservative churches of the Global South. The Anglican case is particularly sharp because the colonial history of the Communion means that the conservative churches of Africa are the institutional children of the liberal churches of England and America — and they are now declaring their independence from their theological parents.

## Anglican Daily Practice and Spirituality

The spiritual practice of Anglicanism is built on two foundations: the Daily Office and the annual liturgical calendar. These two structures — one organizing the day, the other organizing the year — provide the framework within which Anglican spirituality operates.

**THE DAILY OFFICE:** The obligation to pray Morning and Evening Prayer daily is laid on all Anglican clergy; it is commended to laypeople as the appropriate rhythm of Christian prayer. The Daily Office is not a private meditation but a participation in the prayer of the whole Church — the same psalms, the same Scripture readings, the same collects being prayed simultaneously by Anglicans around the world. This corporate dimension of private prayer is one of the most distinctively Anglican spiritual gifts: the person praying Morning Prayer alone in their kitchen is joining the cathedral choir, the solitary monk, and the hospital chaplain in a common act of worship.

**THE COLLECTS:** The collect is the distinctive prayer form of Anglican spirituality — a brief, precisely crafted prayer that gathers the theme of a particular occasion into a single movement: address, acknowledgment, petition, purpose, and conclusion. Cranmer's collects are masterpieces of English prose: "Stir up, O Lord, the will of your faithful people, that they, plenteously bearing the fruit of good works, may by you be plenteously rewarded" (Collect for the Last Sunday before Advent). "Almighty God, whose most dear Son went not up to joy but first he suffered pain, and entered not into glory before he was crucified: mercifully grant that we, walking in the way of the cross, may find it none other than the way of life and peace" (Collect for Palm Sunday).

**THE LITURGICAL CALENDAR:** The Anglican calendar follows the traditional Western liturgical year — Advent, Christmas, Epiphany, Lent, Holy Week, Easter, Pentecost, and the long season after Pentecost (Trinity season) in which the ordinary weeks of the year are organized. The sanctoral calendar — the feast days of saints — is less rigorously observed in most Anglican churches than in Catholic practice, but the major feasts (Christmas, Epiphany, Ash Wednesday, Palm Sunday, Maundy Thursday, Good Friday, Easter Vigil, Ascension, Pentecost, Trinity Sunday, All Saints) structure the spiritual year with a rhythm of fasting and feasting, penitence and celebration, that has formed Anglican spirituality for five centuries.

**CONFIRMATION:** In Anglican practice, Confirmation — the formal affirmation of the baptismal covenant by a person who was baptized as an infant, administered by the bishop with the laying on of hands — marks the transition to full communicant membership. Preparation for Confirmation typically involves instruction in the faith using the catechism of the prayer book (covering the Apostles' Creed, the Ten Commandments, the Lord's Prayer, and the sacraments) and may last several months. In progressive Anglican provinces, Confirmation is sometimes treated more as a commissioning for service than as the completion of Christian initiation (which is understood as complete in baptism).

## **The Haligricity Lens — The Via Media as Sacred Hospitality**

Anglicanism offers the Haligric practitioner something that no other tradition in the library offers with quite the same institutional embodiment: a tradition that has, from its origins, chosen breadth over precision — a tradition that builds its identity not around the sharp boundaries of doctrinal definition but around the shared rhythm of common prayer, and that invites into its life people who hold quite different understandings of what they are doing when they pray together.

## **Lex Orandi, Lex Credendi — The Body Knows Before the Mind**

The Anglican principle that the law of praying is the law of believing is the liturgical tradition's most direct expression of what every contemplative tradition in the library knows about the relationship between practice and understanding. The Sufi who turns in the dhikr knows something about the divine that precedes and exceeds their theological articulation of what they know. The Zen practitioner who sits zazen is cultivating a relationship with the real that their words about it cannot contain. The Anglican who prays the collect "Almighty God, to whom all hearts are open, all desires known, and from whom no secrets are hid" is entering into a relationship with the divine that is more than its theological formulation. Anglicanism built a tradition on this recognition: the liturgy is not the vehicle for the theology. The liturgy is the theology — and the theology is known primarily in the praying.

## **The Via Media — Holding Tension as Sacred Practice**

The Anglican via media — the middle way — is typically described as a compromise between Catholicism and Protestantism, a diplomatic solution to a political problem. But at its best it is something more theologically significant: the recognition that genuine sacred truth tends to be larger than any single tradition's grasp of it, and that the proper response to this largeness is not premature certainty but the discipline of holding multiple partial truths in creative tension. The evangelical who insists on the authority of Scripture and the Anglo-Catholic who insists on the importance of tradition are both right — and the Anglican tradition at its best has found ways to hold them in conversation rather than forcing a choice between them. The Haligric practitioner who has moved through multiple traditions recognizes this immediately: the via media is not compromise; it is comprehensiveness.

## **Morning Prayer and the Sacred Rhythm of Day**

The Anglican Daily Office — Morning Prayer and Evening Prayer, the rhythm of the day organized around Scripture and praise — is one of the most accessible forms of daily spiritual practice available in any Western tradition. Its structure is simple enough for anyone to follow; its content is rich enough to sustain a lifetime of engagement. The practitioner who prays Morning Prayer daily participates in a practice that is simultaneously personal (their own prayer, their own encounter with the day's Scripture) and communal (the same prayer being offered around the world, connecting the individual to the whole Body of Christ). The collect form — brief, precisely crafted, addressed to a specific divine attribute and requesting a specific grace — is one of the most useful daily prayer forms in any tradition for the practitioner who wants to bring the sacred specifically into the specifics of each day. Grand Rising.